

What about if, like my friend's mother did, you have people depending on you for financial help? What happens to them when you die? And, Shapiro added, what if you have a favorite niece you want to give a specific gift to? Or just something with immense sentimental value that you hope goes to your brother? Shapiro said if those are the case, a will is a good idea for anyone at any age.

Common advice says to create a will when you have children, but if you don't plan on having children, it should be when you have significant assets. I don't specifically have a will (my only non-monetary asset is my very banged-up Toyota Prius), but I've told my mom (and, in the worst case, where my mom and I are both dead, my sister) to divvy everything up as she sees fit. It's a weird discussion to have.

When I was home for Thanksgiving in 2017, we talked about how my little sister has power of attorney (even though she's the youngest sibling). POA means my parents have given her "written authorization to represent or act on another's behalf in private affairs, business, or some other legal matter," according to Wikipedia. I don't mind. My sister has said she'd be okay making the hard decisions if both of my parents were too injured to do so. My mom expressed to us over breakfast that she wants us to give her an "ecologically friendly" funeral. (She's worried about Earth running out of burial space, and also it's less expensive.)

My mom's mom and my dad's stepdad have physical grave sites that we visit every so often, but I've stopped feeling an emotional connection to the spots. It's like the Mary Elizabeth Frye poem "Do not stand at my grave and weep / I am not there I do not sleep." My mom agreed with me.

A few years ago, she asked me what I'd want her to do if I died beyond donating my organs to help others. (That's just my wish. I know it freaks some people out.) I told her to guess what I'd want. She said I'd want to be cremated and then have the ashes sprinkled on the lawns of my enemies. What a cheap option!

